

Proseminar

Miss Lonelyhearts and Loneliness in the City

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Alfred Hitchcock's film, *Rear Window* (1954) unfolds mostly within the confines of a single apartment, yet it manages to explore several characters who live in various New York apartments that surround a courtyard. The film's plot follows Jeffries, a photographer journalist confined to his apartment due to an injury he sustained at his profession. As he is stuck in his wheelchair, he passes the time observing his many different neighbors through his rear window. This leads to him becoming embroiled in a murder mystery over Mr. Thorwald's seemingly missing wife. However, in this essay I want to focus specifically on a rather minor character- Miss Lonelyhearts. As Jeffries looks out of his window at his neighbors' domestic lives he sees Miss Lonelyhearts. She is a single woman living alone in a bottom floor apartment opposite Jeffries. In this essay, I will argue that the character of Miss Lonelyhearts highlights the pervasive loneliness and alienation experienced by individuals in modern cities supported by academic sources that delve into the film's themes and techniques.

First of all, Miss Lonelyhearts' solitary existence and her failed interactions with potential lovers that the audience views through her apartment symbolizes the alienation experienced by individuals in urban environments. We first meet Miss Lonelyhearts as Jeffries watches her through his window. She is at home and seems to be having an imaginary date out of sheer loneliness. She imagines a fake man and invites the fake man in. She pretends to take his hat and sits down at the table where she prepared a romantic dinner. Only when Miss Lonelyhearts sits

down and looks at the empty chair in front of her does she collapse into tears. Her failed interactions with male suitors underscore the superficiality and lack of genuine connection prevalent in modern society. We learn Miss Lonelyhearts is rather unlucky in love in a few scenes. In one scene she is seen getting ready for a date, putting on lipstick and choosing the right hat. However, when she enters the restaurant, it appears that she is all alone, perhaps she was stood up. In her next scene, she brings back a man that she met. Jeffries says to Lisa that Miss Lonelyhearts' date appears to be much younger than she is- already hinting that this connection is not fully genuine. They seem to be getting along until he forcefully kisses her until she slaps him and kicks him out of her apartment. After kicking him out, Miss Lonelyhearts cries before falling onto her sofa in tears. As we view her through a window, through a window, and then through our screens a feeling of alienation between us and Miss Lonelyhearts is created. "In the patterns of their comings and goings Jeffries's neighbors become for him caricatures rather than characters, two-dimensional oddities rather than fully human fellow creatures." (Miller 51) The limited spatial boundaries as well as the mise en scene of a small, somewhat cramped unfashionable apartment underscore the theme of loneliness in an urban area. Robin Wood's "An Introduction to the American Horror Film," explores the "concept of Otherness" which provides an interesting framework to analyze the character of Miss Lonelyhearts. Wood's analysis of horror films emphasizes the genre's ability to articulate deep-seated anxieties and societal tensions.

One might say that the true subject of the horror genre is the struggle for recognition of all that our civilization represses or oppresses [...] the "happy ending" (when it exists) typically signifying the restoration of repression. (Wood 201)

By aligning ourselves with Jeffries's point of view, we are categorizing Miss Lonelyhearts as an "other." Along with Jeffries, the audience judges Miss Lonelyhearts seemingly pathetic life. She is middle-aged, single, and is not successful in finding a significant relationship. Most of her scenes end with her collapsing into tears. So Jeffries can feel better about his relationship with

Lisa, he compares her to Miss Lonely hearts. This causes the audience to compare Lisa and Miss Lonelyhearts to each other- Lisa is a successful blond who is played by the beautiful Grace Kelly. From that, the audience can presume that Miss Lonelyhearts is her opposite and therefore not only unattractive, but a failure. "Miss Lonelyhearts represents a visual reminder to [Lisa], as well as to viewers, that the stakes in the game they are playing are high and that the costs of failures are significant." (Miller 47) Wood argues that societal fears and taboos manifest through the narrative's subtext. This subtext is present in Miss Lonelyheart's ending in the film. "[the bourgeois deals with 'the Other' in two ways:] either assimilating it, converting it as far as possible into a replica of itself" (Wood 199) At the end of the film, she is saved from her suicide by the music she hears her pianist neighbor playing. They talk and seem to be beginning a romantic relationship with one another. Miss Lonelyheart is no longer seemingly single by the end of the film. Does this mean she is no longer lonely?

In Miss Lonelyhearts, Jeffries encounters the spectacle of human suffering presented in shockingly unsentimental fashion as petition, a demand addressed impersonally but directly at him. In response, he can offer little more than deflections: a detached smile, a raised glass, and the bestowal of a pet nickname. (Miller 47)

By Miss Lonelyhearts adhering to the social order by the end of the film, we can further conclude that her character throughout the film was lonely and pathetic. Now that she has love, she is no longer sad. Miss Lonelyhearts assimilating away from the "other" she is no longer herself. She is not lonely, so what is she? For Jeff and the audience, it seems like she is nothing more than a spectacle.

Furthermore, The voyeuristic nature of Jeffries's observations of Miss Lonelyhearts and her neighbors underscores the theme of isolation and detachment in urban life, emphasizing the anonymity and alienation experienced by individuals in a densely populated environment.

Throughout the film Jeffries observes his neighbors from his rear window. He gives each of them a nickname, since he does not really know them. He is bound to his wheelchair due to an injury he sustained while working as a photographer and is unable to go outside- all he can do is sit and watch from a distance.

The open courtyard behind Jeffries's Greenwich Village apartment can be viewed as a microcosm of the city, and Jeffries finds himself surrounded by people that he knows only by sight, but not through conversation or personal interaction. This tension between physical proximity and social distance sets an uneasy tone. (Coon 59)

Visually, Hitchcock frames us and builds the set to make the apartments in the courtyard very close to each neighbor, despite only viewing them from Jeffries's window. This closeness allows Jeffries to engage in voyeurism. Jeffries is able to see a multitude of things, from private matters such as Miss Torso going into her bathroom to public affairs that he sees when he looks into the street away from the courtyard. "The people visible from Jeffries's window (other tenants, delivery people, passing strangers) demonstrate the mix of temporary and permanent inhabitants" (Coon 59). Despite being in a large city, the open courtyard is caged by the dense apartment complexes giving a sense of suffocation and invasion. "The closed isolation creates a sense of claustrophobia while the penetrable openness creates a sense of vulnerability" (Coon 58). This voyeuristic nature of Jeffries's observations, particularly of Miss Lonelyhearts and Miss Torso, aligns with Laura Mulvey's theory of the male gaze as explored in "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema." Mulvey argues that cinema, as a visual medium, often reinforces patriarchal power dynamics through the objectification of female characters for the pleasure of male viewers (Mulvey 808-809). This is visible in his naming of an attractive blond neighbor Miss Torso due to her attractive body and naming Miss Lonelyhearts due to her lack of romantic companionship. Jeffries objectifies his female neighbors by reducing them to objects of sexuality or lack thereof. Jeffries's gaze serves as a manifestation of the male gaze, reducing the genuine human interaction

to a spectacle for his voyeuristic consumption. Through the lens of Mulvey's theory, we understand that Jeffries is reducing Miss Lonelyhearts and along with his other neighbors to a mere object of his scrutiny.

The look is central to the plot, oscillating between voyeurism and fetishistic fascination. [...] Hitchcock's skillful use of identification processes and liberal use of subjective camera from the point of view of the male protagonist draw the spectators deeply into his position, making them share his uneasy gaze (Mulvey 813)

In one scene, Jeffries's neighbors discover that their dog has been killed. The owner of the dog screams at all the neighbors: "You don't know the meaning of the word neighbors. Neighbors like each other, speak to each other, care if anybody lives or dies. But none of you do!" This quote exposes the true nature of this courtyard and the city itself- it is lonely, no one knows each other or cares to. The only person who assists them and responds to them is Miss Lonelyheart who assists them by putting their dog in the basket. Miss Lonelyheart operated from a place of neighborliness, meanwhile that is not noticed because we, along with Jeffries, are focused on Thorwald.

The meaning of the word neighbor is, of course, precisely what Jeffries takes for granted, choosing to regard proximity as nine-tenths of the law when defining his own role within his community (Miller 51)

Furthermore, Mulvey argues that the cinematic apparatus, including camera techniques and narrative structures, perpetuates the objectification of female characters, reinforcing patriarchal norms and power dynamics. In *Rear Window*, Hitchcock employs cinematic techniques such as camera movement to emphasize Jeffries's voyeuristic perspective, shown by how Jeffries stares at Miss Torso doing her daily dance practice while the camera lingers on her. This complicity implicates the audience in perpetuating the objectification of female characters. This distinction

between neighbor and stranger is not made by Jeffries, by the end of the film he is still strangers with his neighbors, except for Thorwald, who he put in jail.

Miss Lonelyhearts' suicide attempt, witnessed by Jeffries and the audience, serves as a commentary on the profound sense of despair and hopelessness that can result from a lack of meaningful human connection in a modern, urban setting. Towards the end of the film, as Jeffries and Stella are watching Lisa attempt to break into Mr. Thorwald's apartment, Stella's focus shifts to Miss Lonelyhearts' apartment. There she sees Miss Lonelyhearts in a robe taking a handful of red pills and laying them out on a side table. As Jeffries and Stella discuss how those pills are dangerous and can kill her, Lisa returns to the apartment and their focus shifts back to the Thorwald mystery. As Jeffries conducts his murder mystery, he ironically neglects his neighbor when she needs him most. Metz's "The Imaginary Signifier" delves into the concept of mirror identification. Mirror identification occurs when viewers identify with characters on screen, projecting their own desires and anxieties onto them (Metz 45-46). In *Rear Window*, viewers identify with Jeffries, and Jeffries continues to not truly pay attention to Miss Lonelyhearts, emphasizing her loneliness and despair. This identification softens the emotional impact of her suicide attempt as unimportant, highlighting the distant nature of cities.

[Film] differs from the primordial mirror in one essential point: although, as in the latter, everything may come to be projected, there is one thing, and one thing only that is never reflected in it: the spectator's own body. In a certain emplacement, the mirror suddenly becomes clear glass. (Metz 45)

In "Architecture of the Gaze: Jeffries Apartment and Courtyard," Jacobs discussed the different aesthetic choices made by Hitchcock when building the set and how it was meant to convey a feeling of urban isolation. "[Anonymous neighbors] that are part of a Gesellschaft of autonomous individuals. The inhabitants live rather isolated from each other" (Jacobs 293). In *Rear Window*,

this distinction is particularly significant, as viewers engage with the narrative through the intermediary of the screen. The glass barrier between the audience and Miss Lonelyhearts serves to isolate her further, emphasizing the sense of distance and detachment inherent in urban life.

Precisely the relative isolation and the lack of interference in the everyday life of others are the attractive elements of the big city life. The story of *Rear Window* is unthinkable in a small town or in suburbia since the balance between individualism and collectivity is completely different in such places. (Jacobs 295)

As Jeffries tries to call Mr. Thorwald, we cut to a short shot of Miss Lonelyhearts, with her window shades down, preparing to end her own life. Stella and Lisa even go downstairs later in the sequence, positioned right outside Miss Lonelyhearts' window, and didn't consider checking on her. When Jeffries sees Miss Lonelyhearts writing what appears to be a suicide note, he misunderstands and doesn't seem to think it is dangerous and says, "Stella was wrong about Miss Lonelyhearts."

[The courtyard] provides the lonely surveyor with an overview of many separated individuals. As the panopticon, the urban courtyard belongs to a modern society without a ritual mediation between particular individuals (Jacobs 293)

Metz also discusses the similarities between film and dreams, suggesting that both mediums operate through a logic of the unconscious (Metz 101). "The spectator lets himself be carried away- perhaps deceived, for the space of a second- by the anagogic powers belonging to a diegetic film" (Metz 102). In *Rear Window*, Hitchcock blurs the boundaries between reality and fantasy, inviting viewers to navigate the fragmented narrative through Jeffries's voyeuristic gaze. This blurring of reality and fantasy mirrors the disjointed nature of urban life, where genuine human connection is elusive and fleeting. As soon as Stella returns to the apartment and sees Miss

Lonelyhearts with the letter and the pills, she understands the situation and tells Jeffries to call the police. However, when he does, Miss Lonelyhearts suddenly stops and begins to listen to the music being played by her pianist neighbor above her. As soon as that is resolved for Jeffries, he goes right back to the Thorwald mystery.

In conclusion, Alfred Hitchcock's *Rear Window* uses Miss Lonelyhearts to symbolize the widespread loneliness and isolation felt by individuals living in the city. By looking through Jeffries's voyeuristic perspective, we are faced with the truth of isolation and detachment. Miss Lonelyhearts, residing near but isolated from her neighbors, represents the challenges of contemporary city living, where shallow encounters and unsuccessful relationships illustrate a lack of authentic bonding. The voyeuristic look, shared by Jeffries and the audience, diminishes individuals such as Miss Lonelyhearts to objects of observation, strengthening societal expectations and isolating individuals. The way Hitchcock composes and designs the crowded courtyard highlights the feeling of being anonymous and disconnected in the crowded urban environment, where being physically close doesn't necessarily mean being socially connected. Miss Lonelyhearts' suicide attempt shows the despair and hopelessness that can come from not having a meaningful human connection. Even though Jeffries and the audience saw her attempt, her story is overlooked due to the growing mystery surrounding Thorwald. This narrative decision emphasizes the disconnect and apathy found in city life, allowing people like Miss Lonelyhearts to go unnoticed and uncared for.

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